

EUROPEAN UNION



FIFTEEN COUNTRIES have joined together to form the European Union (EU). But Europe was not always at peace. Between 1870 and 1945, France and Germany were at war three

times. Determined to ensure their two countries never fought each other again, the French and Germans decided to link their coal and steel industries so their nations would be forced to work together. The creation of the European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC) in 1951 led to today's European Union.

Uniting Europe

In 1957, the ECSC evolved into the wider European Economic Community (EEC). Ten years later this became the European Community (EC). In 1991, EC leaders signed the Maastricht Treaty, which started Europe towards full economic and monetary union. When the treaty came into force in 1993, the EC became the European Union (EU).

The growing union

The European Union has 15 members. A further 13 states have applied for membership, with more considering joining. Trade and cooperation agreements are already in place between the EU and many applicants. Switzerland has close trade links with the EU, but a national referendum in 2001 rejected joining.

Date of joining

- 1957
- 1973
- 1981
- 1986
- 1995
- Membership applications



Members of the EU, 2001



The euro

On 1 January 2002, a single currency, the euro, was fully launched in 12 countries of the European Union (EU).

The notes and coins of this new currency replaced the national currencies of those nations.

The only EU countries to stay out of the monetary union were Britain, Denmark, and Sweden.

Structure of the EU

The EU has three main institutions: the Commission, based in Brussels, Belgium, is the civil service which runs the EU; the Parliament, in Strasbourg, France, and Brussels, provides control over the EU; the European Court of Justice, in Luxembourg, makes sure EU laws are applied properly.



European Parliament

Every five years, adults throughout the EU go to the polls to elect 626 Members of the European Parliament (MEPs) to represent their interests. Although it does not have the same powers as a national parliament, the European Parliament advises the Commission and supervises its work and annual budget.

What the EU does

The European Union has many different roles covering economic, financial, commercial, political, industrial, agricultural, social, and cultural matters. Its two main achievements have been to establish free trade between the member states by abolishing customs duties, and to set up a common agricultural and fisheries policy.



Agricultural policy

In order to guarantee food supplies and increase agricultural productivity, the EU runs a very complex Common Agricultural Policy (CAP). This has established free movement of farm produce throughout the EU.



The EU has sponsored a common European passport.

Social policy

The EU tries to improve employment for unemployed workers and young people by investing in education and training in deprived regions. It has also established a common Social Chapter of Workers' Rights.



EU aid

The EU provides subsidies to the less well-off regions of Europe, for projects such as developing new industries. Much EU aid is targeted towards improving transport links in Europe, such as building roads and railways, so all regions can share in the benefits of the single market.

Timeline

1951 European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC) is set up.



1957 The ECSC nations sign the Treaty of Rome, setting up the European Economic Community (EEC); a separate treaty sets up the European Atomic Energy Community (Euratom).

1967 ECSC, EEC, and Euratom merge to form the European Community (EC).

1979 European Monetary System set up to link currencies.

1991 Maastricht Treaty sets out timetable for full economic union.

1993 EC becomes the European Union (EU).

2002 The euro replaces existing currencies in 12 EU countries.



Jean Monnet

Jean Monnet (1888–1979) was a French economist who convinced the French foreign minister, Robert Schuman (1886–1963), that the only way to avoid another war between France and Germany was to integrate their coal and steel industries. The ECSC was set up with Monnet as its first president. His vision led directly to the development of today's EU.

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